PERadoxical Cert-ainty: Rethinking the Accuracy-Access Tradeoff in SNAP

July Spector-Bishop*

October 31, 2026

Abstract

Recent federal policy changes have compelled states to prioritize payment accuracy over access to benefits in the Supplemental Nutrition Assistance Program (SNAP). Some states have required participants to recertify more frequently in order to verify that eligibility and benefit determinations are accurate, but such requirements threaten to reduce program take-up by increasing administrative burdens. I find preliminary evidence that shorter certification periods can have the opposite of their intended effect: increasing the administrative workload faced by state agencies, thus leading to more errors. Using public-use SNAP Quality Control data, I show that eligible non-elderly households are more likely to have a payment error if they certified during a quarter in which state agencies had to process more recertifications due to shorter elderly certification periods. This paper contributes to the sparse literature on the causes of SNAP Payment Error Rates (PER) and re-frames payment accuracy as the output of overall administrative quality rather than one side of an accuracy-access tradeoff.

1 Introduction

Accurately determining eligibility and benefits is a perennial concern for social safety net programs. However, efforts to ensure that benefits only flow to the needy can impose onerous administrative burdens on program recipients. Under this view, policymakers face a choice: do you make it easier to apply and risk overpaying benefits, or do you increase eligibility verification requirements and risk driving the needy away from the program if they cannot navigate the additional paperwork? In the case of the Supplemental Nutrition Assistance Program (SNAP), this is sometimes framed as an accuracy-access tradeoff between program participation and the Payment Error Rate (PER), which measures the share of benefits that are later determined to have been mistakenly overpaid or underpaid (Kabbani and Wilde 2003).

Understanding SNAP payment accuracy has taken on a critical new relevance in recent years. Under the 2025 One Big Beautiful Bill Act (OBBBA), states with PERs above 6% will be required to pay for a fraction of SNAP benefits roughly equal to their PER. Given that the average state PER for FY2025 was 9.82%, this will likely impose significant financial penalties on most states (FNS 2026b). For example, Florida would be

*I would like to thank Professors Matthew Tarduno, Darren Lubotsky, and Benjamin Ost of the University of Illinois at Chicago, Donn Feir of the University of Victoria, Sabrina Young of DePaul University, and Marianne Bitler of the University of California, Davis. I would also like to thank Janet Spector-Bishop, John Bishop, Camille Baker, Addison Keefe, and Kevin Johnson, as well as all the SNAP recipients, caseworkers, and policymakers who helped inform this paper.

liable for approximately $912 million annually in SNAP benefits (FNS 2026a). States unable to either afford this price tag or reduce their PER may be forced to withdraw from SNAP, potentially threatening the food security of tens of millions of Americans.

This change incentivizes states to prioritize accuracy over access, leading them to adopt policies which risk jeopardizing access to SNAP for many of the neediest Americans. For example, Illinois opted to require SNAP households to recertify every 6 months, instead of every 12 (IDHS 2025), in order to more frequently verify that recipients are indeed eligible and that their benefit allotments are accurate. Recertification is the process through which SNAP recipients must demonstrate continued eligibility in order to maintain benefits. It has been shown to act as a significant barrier to program access, causing substantial erroneous disenrollment of eligible households (Gray 2019, Homonoff and Somerville 2021), and possibly reducing overall program participation (Mills et al. 2004). Thus, the decision to require more frequent recertification will likely exacerbate these effects on recipients.

While this effect of shorter certification periods is identified in the literature as one side of the accuracy-access tradeoff (Kabbani and Wilde 2003), a lack of research on this topic means that it is unclear whether shorter certification periods are indeed effective at reducing PER. Theoretically, shorter certification periods should increase the frequency with which recipient allotments and eligibility are verified and updated, and thus should improve the accuracy of benefits. However, the small amount of empirical research on this topic provides correlations rather than causally interpretable estimates (Kabbani and Wilde 2003, Mills et al. 2004, Logan et al. 2008).

Separate from this consideration of accuracy versus access, a policy of shorter certification periods may have a significant impact on state SNAP agencies. Certifying and recertifying cases requires substantial resources, constituting the primary category of SNAP administrative spending by states (Geller et al. 2019). Increasing the volume of recertifications that must be processed would increase these demands on administrative resources. This might adversely impact the administrative quality of state agencies, which already cite high staff turnover, job vacancies, and high workload as major factors contributing to PER (APHSA, 2023). This aligns with the fact that about 57% of payment errors in FY2023 were attributed to mistakes made by state agencies (FNS 2025), with 58% of errors occurring during recertification.

For these reasons, it seems plausible that a policy of shorter certification periods could worsen SNAP PER, rather than improve it, by straining state administrative capacity. SNAP recertifications are processed by caseworkers, who will have less time to check a client's information for errors the more recertifications that they have to process per day. While states could theoretically increase funding for SNAP agencies in order to match this increased workload, a net increase in funding may be difficult to achieve given that the OBBBA also significantly cuts SNAP administrative funding (Feeding America 2026). Increasing the frequency of recertification will increase recertification workload relative to a fixed budget constraint, and this has the potential to degrade the quality with which cases are administered, possibly increasing PER.

This paper uses public-use SNAP Quality Control (QC) data for FY2022-2024 to test the hypothesis that shorter certification periods can worsen payment accuracy to the degree that they increase administrative workload. It uses the average certification periods assigned to different subsets of SNAP cases as an

instrument for the share of a state's caseload that recertifies in a given quarter, which I use as a proxy for the administrative workload faced by state agencies. From this, I estimate the local average treatment effect of recertification workload on the PER and Case Error Rate among eligible SNAP cases.

I find evidence that shorter certification periods can increase the administrative workload faced by state agencies, thus leading to more errors. Eligible non-elderly households are more likely to have a payment error if they certified during a quarter in which state agencies had to process more recertifications. My results suggest that decreasing the certification period assigned to elderly/disabled households from 24 to 12 months would increase the quarterly share of cases recertifying by 6.8 percentage points. This would cause the share of eligible non-elderly households with payment errors to increase by 2.6 percentage points, relative to a quarterly average share of 12.9% for this group. This indicates that certification periods can affect the rate of payment errors through administrative quality, not solely through a simple tradeoff between access and accuracy. However, these results are not robust across specifications, and a number of econometric limitations must be resolved before they can be taken as definitive. In particular, significance drops to 10% under weak instrument robust statistical inference. Additionally, administrative spillovers are only one way in which changing a state's certification period might affect their PER. The net treatment effect may run in the opposite direction if the other mechanisms dominate.

This paper makes several contributions. Firstly, it is the first paper in almost 20 years to examine the relationship between certification periods and payment accuracy in SNAP. It is the first to causally identify the effect of recertification workload on SNAP PER among eligible SNAP cases, and considers the role that certification period length may play in contributing to this workload. This contributes to the extremely small literature on factors and policies causing SNAP payment errors. A better understanding of PER is crucial, as states seek strategies to reduce their PER in response to recent federal policy changes. Secondly, I contribute to the public administration literature on safety net programs by considering the administrative burdens faced by workers at state agencies, which have gone relatively understudied.

Thirdly, I show that, in the case of SNAP, the focus on the accuracy-access tradeoff may be misplaced. While such a tradeoff likely exists in many contexts, it explains relatively little of the variation in payment accuracy or program participation in SNAP. Instead, I argue that other factors, such as overall administrative quality, are likely more relevant to most states interested in improving their PER.

2 Background

2.1 Setting

The Supplemental Nutrition Assistance Program (SNAP) is the largest federal means-tested near-cash public assistance program in the United States, and is intended to help low-income households afford food by providing monthly food vouchers. It differs from other major cash and near-cash assistance programs in that it is available to individuals regardless of family structure, disability, or age. Benefit amounts primarily depend on income and household size. As of FY2025, it provided $96 billion in benefits to 42 million monthly recipients (FNS 2026c).

The benefits allotted to a household are calculated based on the household's size, income, and a number of deductions. This allotment can become incorrect if a household's circumstances change, or if they become ineligible. Thus, households that successfully apply for SNAP are only certified to receive benefits for a specific length of time, after which they must recertify. While the specifics can vary, recertification typically involves an interview with a caseworker and submitting documentation relevant to program eligibility and benefit amounts. States enjoy broad discretion over how they assign certification periods: up to 12 months for most households, and up to 24 or 36 months for households in which all members are either elderly or disabled. The most common certification periods in my data (covering FY2022-FY2024) were 6, 12, 24, and 36 months. Depending on their certification period, households are also required to report information to state agencies between recertifications. The most common interim reporting regime is simplified reporting. While the specifics can vary between states, households assigned to simplified reporting are only required to report interim changes that would make them ineligible for SNAP based on their gross income (Fannin 2025).

SNAP is jointly run by the federal and state governments. The federal Food and Nutrition Service (FNS) of the US Department of Agriculture (USDA) establishes broad program rules and provides funding for benefits, while state human-services agencies perform the work of determining applicants' eligibility and calculating their benefit allotments. This program structure potentially creates a principal-agent problem where states have little incentive to avoid over-issuing benefits because the federal government is the one that pays for these overissuances. The SNAP Quality Control (QC) system was created to address this. Each annual QC review randomly selects a sample of active SNAP cases in each state, totaling approximately 50,000 cases. QC reviewers at state agencies intensively audit these cases, seeking to fully verify participant information and identify payment errors based on criteria set down by the FNS. Then, federal QC reviewers re-audit approximately half of these cases and calculate an annual Payment Error Rate (PER) for each state. Historically, FNS has penalized states based on their performance, levying $102 million in liabilities in FY2023 on states with high PER (FNS 2025), thus incentivizing them to improve.

A state's annual PER represents the dollar amount of benefits that the state issued in error, as a fraction of all SNAP benefits issued in that state. A payment error occurs when a state underissues SNAP benefits to a participating household, overissues SNAP benefits to a participating household, or issues benefits to an ineligible household. The official PER is the sum of two components: the overpayment PER and underpayment PER. While the full FNS methodology for both PER components is complex, it can be roughly characterized as an adjusted ratio of average under/overpayments per case to the average allotments issued per case[1]. The national PER for FY2025 was 10.6%, with state PER varying from Alaska's 23.15% to Idaho's 3.85% (FNS 2026b). PER has risen dramatically since the pandemic, with the national PER peaking at 11.7% in FY2023, compared to 7.4% in FY2019.

If a household is ruled ineligible by QC reviewers then its entire benefit amount is counted as being in error, and counted as overpayment. Additionally, for each eligible case, QC reviewers calculate the correct benefit amount for the month reviewed based on the information obtained in their audit. The difference between this amount and the actual benefits issued is only counted as a payment error if it is greater than

[1]The ratio is adjusted based on the difference between state and federal QC findings, state completion rate and methodology, and state SE. See federal regulation 7 CFR 275.23(b) for more details.

an annually adjusted tolerance threshold set by FNS. For FY2024 this threshold was $56. Thus, an eligible case whose benefit amount in the reviewed month is off by $56 or less is counted as having a payment error of 0, while a case whose benefits are off by $57 is counted as having a payment error of $57. These can either be an overpayment or an underpayment.

The One Big Beautiful Bill Act (OBBBA), signed July 4, 2025, changes SNAP's federal-state balance. Starting in FY2028, states with a PER above 6% will have to pay for a fraction of SNAP benefits roughly equal to their PER in either FY2025 or FY2026, depending on which year a state chooses (Feeding America 2026, Ward 2025). Based on the PER figures from FY2025, 37 states and territories would be required to pay for a share of benefits. This will likely impose significant financial penalties on many of these states, and will mark the first time in the program's history that states would be required to pay for a portion of benefits. Among many other changes to SNAP, the OBBBA also cuts federal reimbursement for state administrative expenses from 50% to 25%, leaving states to cover the gap.

Proponents of these changes argue that these measures are necessary to ensure that states have sufficient "skin in the game" through a "modest state sharing component, so that they'll pay attention to that, so that we can reduce fraud" (Johnson, 2025). For context, the USDA emphatically states that PER is not a measure of fraud, and that most payment errors occur due to administrative errors on the part of state agencies (FNS 2025, USDA 2025). Critics of this new policy contend that it sets states up to fail by demanding better outcomes on short deadlines with fewer administrative resources. They argue that the existing system of fines already incentivized payment accuracy and that the real goal of the policy is to reduce SNAP caseloads by leaving states with no choice but to either adopt more burdensome eligibility screenings or to withdraw from SNAP entirely (Bergh and Rosenbaum 2026, FRAC 2025). There is one point of clear agreement between these perspectives: the OBBBA puts immense and unprecedented pressure on states to lower their PER.

2.2 Past Literature

The accuracy-access tradeoff is a defining feature of the conversation surrounding PER, and thus one cannot discuss the literature on PER without also discussing the literature on program access and administrative burden. Kabbani and Wilde (2003) argue that "caseload declines [are] one dimension of a tradeoff states may have faced between encouraging program participation and lowering QC error rates". This framing remains prominent in the literature to this day (Fannin 2025). Under this view, state SNAP policymakers must balance the conflicting needs to both thoroughly verify that accurate benefit amounts are only paid to eligible households, and also to ensure that paperwork and verification requirements aren't so onerous that they prevent the needy from obtaining benefits.

Despite the prevalence of this framing, the small existing literature does not provide definitive evidence that shorter certification periods do reduce PER. Kabbani and Wilde (2003) use a two-way fixed effects model to estimate that a 10 percentage point increase in the use of short certification periods (3 months or less) is associated with a .6-.81 percentage point reduction in PER. Using a state fixed effects model with state time trends, Logan et al. (2008) find an association between short certification periods and a lower composite error index, though the magnitude of this is difficult to interpret. In addition to the standard limitations of

fixed-effects models (Goodman-Bacon 2021), these estimates are not causally identified because certification period policies are not randomly assigned. In particular, states may set policy in response to their PER, producing reverse causation bias. Mills et al. (2004) use a Markov chain model to show a directionally inconsistent association between shorter certification periods and lower errors. In addition to lacking causal identification, these results are constrained by data limitations that necessitate extremely strong assumptions in the construction of their transition matrix. While helpful, these papers provide suggestive evidence at best for a relationship between short certification periods and payment errors in SNAP[2].

The evidence that short certification periods reduce program participation is somewhat stronger. Both Kabbani and Wilde (2003) and Mills et al. (2004) find that shorter certification periods correspond with steep declines in participation, much larger than their estimated impact on payment errors, though these estimates come with the same caveats discussed in the previous paragraph. Several other papers also document an association between the use of short certification periods and a decline in program participation in the late 1990s and early 2000s (Currie and Grogger 2001, Kornfeld 2002).

Reforms under the 2002 Farm Bill led many states to transition from a system of short certification periods to one of long certification periods and simplified reporting (Hanratty 2006, Logan et al. 2008). In this, it is worth emphasizing the degree to which certification periods and interim-reporting regimes can be thought of as inextricably interrelated policies (Trippe et al. 2004). Several two-way fixed effects papers find that this switch to longer certification periods increased participation, but do not find an effect from simplified reporting (Hanratty 2006, Ratcliffe et al. 2008). Ribar et al. (2008)'s simulation indicates that abandoning short certification periods mechanically increased caseloads in South Carolina. In qualitative interviews, agency staff say that the combination of simplified reporting and longer certification periods improved program access for participants (Trippe et al. 2004). While not causal, this research collectively indicates that, to the extent that short certification periods can be linked to reduced errors, the associated reduction in program participation appears to be much larger.

Research on the process of recertification provides strong evidence for why shorter certification periods might have this effect on participation. The risk of program exit is much higher during recertification (Ribar et al. 2008). This is partially because this is when program rules are enforced (Gray et al. 2023). However, several papers find that as many as half of households exiting during recertification likely remained eligible (Gray 2019, Homonoff and Somerville 2021, Mills et al. 2014), with the first two of these papers providing strong quasi-experimental evidence that such program exits are substantially caused by administrative burdens created by the recertification process[3]. If undergoing the recertification process often causes eligible households to arbitrarily lose benefits, then we might expect more frequent recertification to multiply this effect, reducing overall program participation.

Taken together, existing empirical research does not provide definitive evidence that an accuracy-access tradeoff actually exists in the case of SNAP certification periods. Such a tradeoff would require that shorter certification periods cause lower payment errors and lower program participation, all else equal. Instead,

[2]SNAP was named the Food Stamp Program at the time that these papers were written.

[3]Clarifying terminology: In this literature, the term "administrative burden" refers to the psychological, compliance, and learning costs that a program imposes on its recipients (Herd and Moynihan 2019). I use the term "administrative workload" to refer to the burdens faced by state agency workers in the course of administering the program.

the research on certification period length only provides us with suggestive evidence that they might be associated with PER, though the evidence on program participation is slightly stronger. Additionally, more frequent verification of eligibility and benefits is only one channel through which certification periods might affect PER, and, as I argue in the Conceptual Framework section, there may be other countervailing channels.

Unfortunately for states seeking strategies to reduce their PER in response to the OBBBA, past research does not tell us very much about how certification periods affect payment accuracy in 2026. Between automatic data matching, online applications, the rollout of EBT, and many other changes, the practicalities of administering and interacting with SNAP are dramatically different from when those papers were written. The PER measure itself has changed to a degree that what was true of it in the 1990s may no longer be true today. The present study builds on this previous work as the first paper in almost 20 years to examine the relationship between certification periods and payment accuracy in SNAP, and by being the first to causally identify part of this relationship[4].

What does seem clear is that much of the variation in PER seems to be explained by changes to the measurement of PER itself. While simplified reporting policies have been found to reduce PER, much of this effect is likely attributable to the fact that it causes fewer things to technically count as errors for the purpose of calculating PER (Fannin 2025, Logan et al. 2008, USDA 2005, Trippe et al. 2004). Of relevance to the present policy context, a CBPP report argues that much of the post-pandemic increase in PER is an artifact caused by changes to how the QC process defines errors, and that these changes artificially inflate the overpayment rate (Rosenbaum and Bergh 2023). Beginning in FY2022, a household was automatically determined to be ineligible for the purposes of PER if its certification period had expired, or if it failed to complete certain QC forms, regardless of whether it was actually eligible (FNS 2022). It is plausible that this change explains the recent rise in PER, given that the fraction of ineligible cases in the QC rose from 1.9% in FY2017-2019 to 3.7% in FY2022-2024 (based on the QC technical documentation).

2.3 Reframing

In the context of the accuracy-access tradeoff, policymakers can be thought of as occupying a production possibility frontier (PPF) between these two program outcomes. A state's position along this PPF reflects differences in state policy preferences between being generous but inaccurate (type I error) or accurate to the point of screening needy families out of the program (type II error). However, this framework's practical relevance depends on how much of the variation in SNAP PER it actually explains, and how much is better explained by other factors.

There is reason to believe that it does not explain SNAP PER very well. To see this, consider the neighboring western states Nevada and Utah, which have similar climates, population densities, and population distributions. They both have lower-than-average PERs of 6.6% and 5.8% respectively (national average for FY2022-24 was 11.3%), and they both process about 94% of SNAP applications within 30 days of receiving them (Application Processing Timeliness, APT). However, one area where they greatly differ is in their

[4] A 2025 conference paper by Issar, Valizadeh, Bryant, and Fischer finds some preliminary evidence that 7-12 month certification periods may be heterogeneously associated with overpayments in FY2003-2019. They also find simplified reporting and vehicle exclusion rules may be associated with lower overpayments.

residents' access to SNAP. In Utah, only about four in ten households below 125% of the Federal Poverty Line (FPL) receive SNAP, while in Nevada more than nine in ten do. Their similar PERs mean that this difference cannot be explained simply by a preference for accuracy over generosity.

These two states are part of a broader pattern shown in Figure 1a: that if there is a PPF-style tradeoff between payment accuracy and generosity, then it is a remarkably flat one. Among the 10 states with the lowest average PER for FY2022-2024 (shown in orange), the Program Access Index (PAI)[5] has a range of 58.75 percentage points. This aligns with the literature's finding that small improvements to PER are associated with a high cost to participation. Additionally, for the majority of states that appear to be operating well interior to the accuracy-access PPF, the marginal tradeoff between these outcomes may be of less practical relevance than finding opportunities to improve both. This suggests that accuracy and access may not necessarily be an either-or choice in practice.

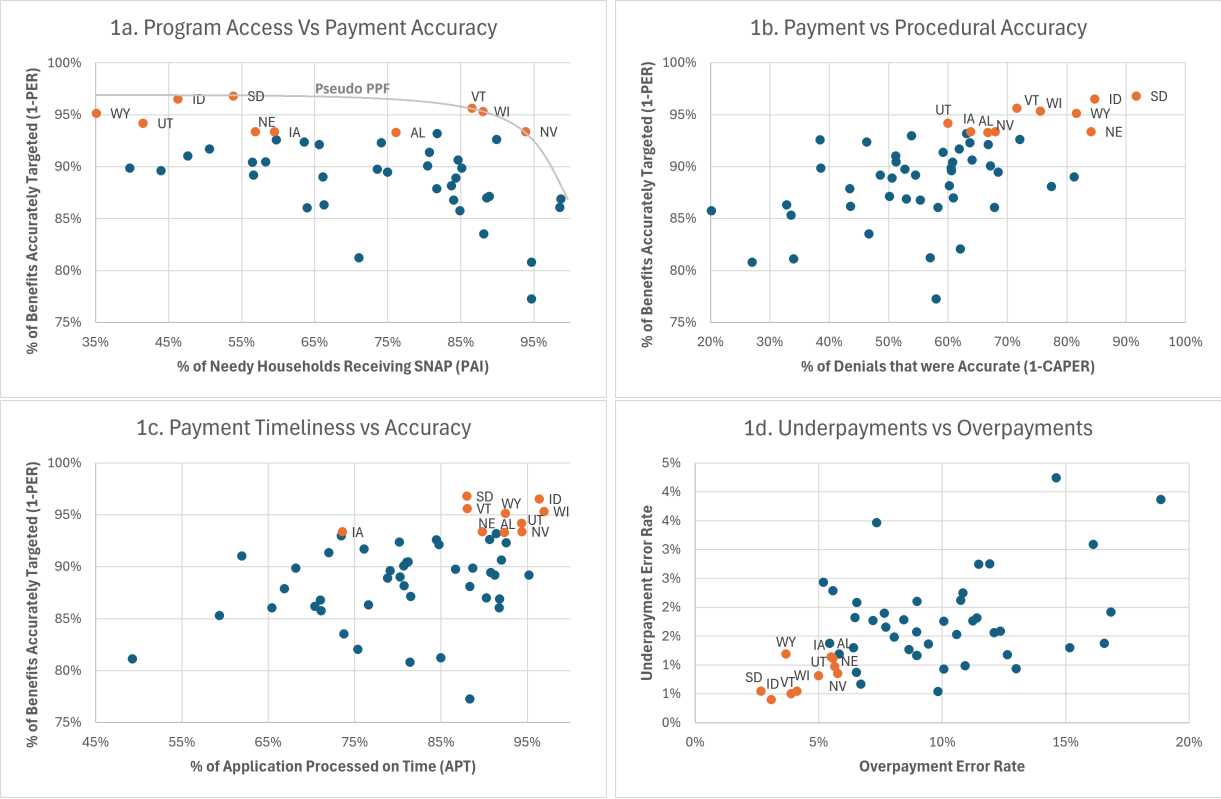


Figure 1: Avg. state level SNAP performance metrics for FY2022-2024. The 10 states with the lowest PER are in orange. 1a shows the relationship between program access (Program Access Index PAI: participation rate among households below 125% of FPL) vs SNAP payment accuracy. 1b shows the relationship between the accuracy of SNAP payments and the accuracy of benefit denials (1- the Case and Procedural Error Rate CAPER). 1c shows the relationship between Application Processing Timeliness (APT) and PER. 1d shows the relationship between the underpayment and overpayment components of PER. Graphs exclude Alaska for the sake of readability.

The rest of Figure 1 further undermines the practical relevance of the accuracy-access tradeoff to explaining PER. If states must choose between false positives and false negatives then we would expect low PER to be associated with higher erroneous denial of benefits by state agencies, which is measured by the USDA's

[5]The USDA's PAI measures the SNAP participation rate among households below 125% of the FPL.

Case and Procedural Error Rate (CAPER). Contrary to this, Figure 1b shows that states which perform well on one metric also tend to perform well on the other. Of the 27 states/territories with an above-median PER (avg. of 2022-2024), 19 of them had above-median CAPER. Similarly, if a state agency is intent on lowering its PER we might expect it to process applications more slowly, sacrificing its Application Processing Timeliness (APT) metric in favor of thoroughness. Instead, Figure 1c shows that states with low PER tend to also process applications quickly.

The characterization of PER as a measure of false positives is itself misleading (Kabbani and Wilde 2003), as it is the sum of both overpayments and underpayments. To the extent that states face a choice between excessive generosity and burdensome restrictiveness then we would expect these two types of payment errors to be inversely related, exhibiting their own sort of PPF. However, Figure 1d demonstrates the opposite: states that avoid issuing too few benefits also tend to avoid mistakenly over-issuing benefits.

While this evidence is descriptive, it demonstrates that PER does not always behave in accordance with what the accuracy-access framework might predict. Instead, high payment accuracy seems to correspond with high performance on other metrics of administrative quality. The importance of administration is underlined by the fact that 57% of payment errors in FY2023 were attributed to mistakes made by state agencies (FNS 2025), with 58% of errors occurring during recertification. While administrative quality is difficult to directly measure, the workload faced by state agencies relative to scarce administrative resources is likely an important component of it. State agencies cite high staff turnover, job vacancies, burnout, and high workload as the major factors contributing to PER (APHSA, 2023)[6], while staff report that the workload reduction from simplified reporting and longer certification periods likely helped reduce PER (Trippe et al. 2004).

The quantity of work relative to administrative resources is also difficult to directly examine. Geller et al. (2019) show that state administrative spending per SNAP case varies by an order of magnitude, possibly indicating that states operate with vastly different production technologies. This may be why they do not find a relationship between a state's PER and its level of administrative spending.

On a practical level, SNAP recertifications are processed by individual caseworkers, who will have less time to check a client's information for errors the more recertifications that they have to process per day, all else equal. Mechanically, the work required to interview and process the recertification paperwork for a household will be doubled if that household is made to recertify twice as often, thus theoretically increasing PER.

In terms of administrative resources, certification is very costly, constituting the primary category of SNAP administrative spending by states (Geller et al. 2019). These costs are exacerbated by "churn", the phenomenon where cases that fail to recertify successfully reapply within 90 days. Processing these reapplications costs states much more in terms of financial and personnel resources than if these households had been correctly recertified (Homonoff and Somerville 2021, Mills et al. 2014). Churn appears to be a common problem, with 17% to 28% of SNAP households experiencing a churn spell in FY2011 (Mills et al. 2014), and San Francisco County having a churn rate of 23.7% in 2014-2016 (Homonoff and Somerville 2021). If

[6]I informally spoke to a number of SNAP caseworkers, who also highlighted these as major factors.

households are required to recertify more often then they will be disenrolled more often (Ribar et al. 2008), and thus reapply more often. Taken together, this means that shorter certification periods will increase the workload faced by caseworkers and administrative staff at state agencies, potentially causing them to make more mistakes. Thus, it is possible that state efforts to reduce PER through shorter certification periods may be counterproductive.

In the long run states could theoretically increase funding for SNAP agencies in order to match the increased workload created by more frequent recertification. However, it cannot be assumed that the budget that state legislatures appropriate for SNAP agencies will be responsive to the demands placed on those agencies, especially if demands on agencies fluctuate frequently. Additionally, new funding takes time to be translated into administrative capacity, as caseworkers must be hired and trained. Finally, in the present context, a net increase in funding may be difficult to achieve given that the OBBBA also significantly cuts SNAP administrative funding (Feeding America 2026). Thus, it seems most realistic to treat state administrative resources as fixed in the immediate term.

In summary, longer certification periods might potentially offer states a win-win, improving both program access and payment accuracy. This possibility, and the role of administration in PER more generally, has not been considered by previous research. The present paper attempts to fill this gap by examining the effect of SNAP certification period length on PER through its impact on state administrative workload. In particular, I hypothesize that adopting shorter certification periods will increase staff workload, straining administrative resources, and that this will increase PER.

3 Conceptual Framework

The present study considers the effect of state policies governing SNAP certification period length on payment accuracy. In particular, I intend to identify the role played by administrative workload faced by states. However, I cannot merely regress these variables on one another because there are several reasons to think that the variation in certification periods is not exogenous to the effect of administrative workload on PER.

Firstly, certification periods are not randomly assigned. States have historically designed certification policies to assign shorter certification to cases that are judged as more likely to have changing circumstances which would affect their eligibility and benefit amount (Kabbani and Wilde 2003). Thus, cases with greater perceived risk of payment error are likely to be assigned to shorter certification periods. This selection would bias a naive estimation of the relationship between certification periods and PER. Secondly, state policymakers may choose to shorten certification periods specifically with the intention of reducing their PER (Kabbani and Wilde 2003), as Illinois did in 2025 (IDHS 2025). These sources of reverse causation would cause shorter certification periods to be associated with higher PER, biasing a regression of the causal relationship.

Additionally, certification period lengths likely affect payment accuracy through more than just their effect on administrative quality. It is helpful to conceptualize three channels through which shorter certification periods may affect PER. Figure 2 provides an illustration of how these channels relate certification

periods and payment errors for non-elderly SNAP households.

First is the verification channel, through which shorter certification periods may reduce PER by increasing the frequency with which recipient allotments and eligibility are verified and updated. This is the channel through which the accuracy side of the accuracy-access tradeoff would operate (Kabbani and Wilde 2003). Past research (Gray 2019, Gray et al. 2023) has shown that SNAP rules are often only functionally enforced upon recertification. The more often a household must submit documentation in order to recertify, the less likely it is that their information and benefit amount are outdated, thus making their allotment more accurate. This mechanism is likely to interact with the details of state interim reporting policies, which govern when and how recipients must report changes during their certification periods.

Second is the caseload composition channel, by which shorter certification periods affect PER through their impact on the composition of the SNAP caseload. This channel can be thought of as a side effect of the access side of the accuracy-access tradeoff, by which shorter certification periods tend to reduce program participation for those who are assigned to them. As a result of this, PER will increase or decrease depending on the probability of error among such cases. For example, cases with earned income are thought to be relatively more prone to payment errors due to their circumstances changing more frequently (Kabbani and Wilde 2003). For this reason, such cases are often assigned to shorter certification periods, which might act to reduce PER through discouraging participation among this group. If, on the other hand, low-error cases were assigned shorter periods, and thus screened out, this might increase PER by reducing the share of correct cases. The effect of this channel will also depend on whether an individual's probability of case closure at recertification is independent of their probability of having an error. Table 1 shows that eligible households where not all members are elderly or disabled have a higher incidence of payment errors and shorter average certification periods, compared to households where all members are elderly or disabled. Thus, ex ante, I expect that this channel will more often tend to reduce PER, but the effect is likely heterogeneous.

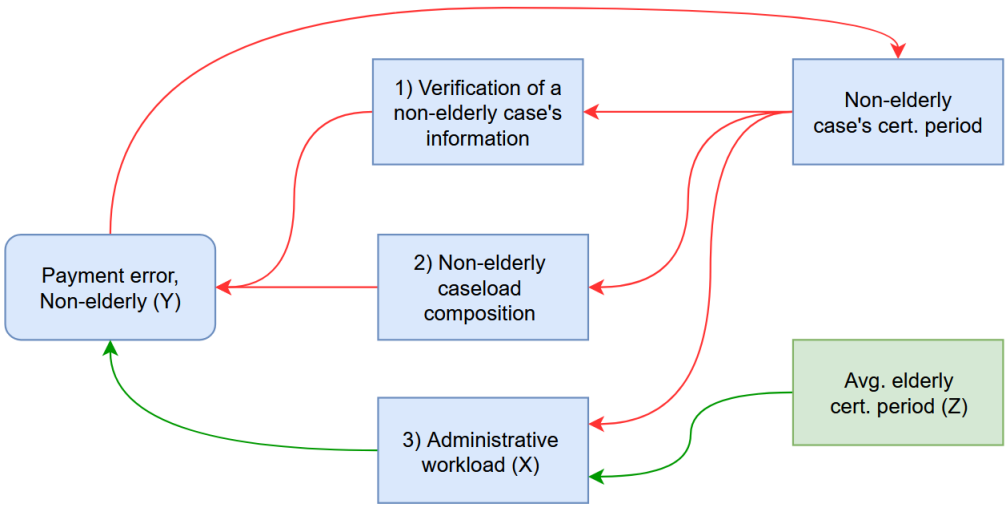


Figure 2: The theoretical causal relationship between certification periods and payment accuracy. Illustrates the verification, caseload composition, and administrative workload channels, as well as reverse causation between PER and certification period length.

Finally, shorter certification periods might increase PER through the administrative workload channel hypothesized in the previous section. Under this mechanism, conducting more frequent recertification of SNAP cases would increase a state SNAP agency's workload, causing administrators to make more mistakes and resulting in higher PER among all types of cases. This is the channel of interest for the present study.

As can be seen in Figure 2, the first and second channels operate through the effect that a case's own certification period has on it. Meanwhile, the administrative workload channel operates through the collective impact that the caseload has on state agencies. A case would be affected by this administrative spillover if its own certification period were held fixed and everyone else's was shortened, all else equal. Thus, I identify the impact of this channel by splitting SNAP cases into two disjoint groups and estimating each group's PER based on the certification periods of the other. More precisely, for a given group of cases g, I use the average certification period among all other cases g^{-1} as an instrument for the fraction of cases recertifying, in order to estimate the local average treatment effect of recertification workload on the PER for group g.

I define the first focal group as all SNAP cases where all members of the household were either elderly (age$\geq$ 60), disabled, or both. I define the second focal group as all SNAP cases where not all members of the household were either elderly or disabled. I refer to these two groups throughout the paper as the elderly and non-elderly groups, and refer to the cases in these groups as elderly and non-elderly cases. Using these groupings has several advantages. Cases are relatively unlikely to intentionally select into one group or the other for reasons of manipulating their certification period, as one cannot alter their age, and cannot easily alter their disability status. While several past studies have considered households with and without earned income, this potentially introduces selection bias if households alter their employment in response to certification policies.

Additionally, it seems plausible that each group's certification period is relatively independent of the other's. Federal policy considers these to be distinct groups, allowing for a much higher maximum certification period for the elderly. Many states also have policies which separately define certification periods for the elderly, such as the Elderly Simplified Application Project (ESAP). Both state and federal governments also tend to treat elderly/disabled SNAP cases differently along other policy dimensions as well. For example, federal law exempts them from work requirements, and many states have adopted the Combined Application Project to ease program participation for this group. Meanwhile, non-elderly cases are generally not treated with such leniency. While hardly proof of independence, the fact that these groups of SNAP participants are treated so differently by the program suggests that their certification periods can be considered distinct policies with their own distinct determinants.

This approach has the added benefit of avoiding reverse causation. If state policymakers are concerned about high PER among the non-elderly, then they might change certification periods for the non-elderly but they are unlikely to specifically change the certification period for the elderly.

4 Data

I use the public-use SNAP Quality Control Database for FY2022-2024[7] as my primary data source because the QC is the primary microdata from which PER is derived, and because it provides a highly detailed repeated cross-section of SNAP participants. PER is an evaluation of a state SNAP program's accuracy, and this paper seeks to study the impact of the workload faced by state agencies. Therefore, the state is the appropriate unit of analysis. For my primary analysis I aggregate the QC data into a state-by-quarter dataset and construct quarterly PER. I choose quarter level aggregation because annual aggregations would lack sufficient power, while monthly cells would sometimes only contain a few dozen cases for each focal group, which would limit key variables' precision and support. Additionally, I perform robustness checks using the case level QC data for the same time period.

Out of 130,058 initial SNAP cases, I dropped 101 cases because they were excluded from the official error rate calculation, most of which were in Minnesota in FY2024. A further 61 cases were dropped due to missing key certification variables. I also drop all cases in Delaware and Guam due to serious data quality concerns[8]. I further drop 12,936 cases for whom the instrument (defined in the Methods section) was not observable. I then aggregate the remaining 115,115 SNAP cases at the state-quarter level. From this state-quarter data I further drop all quarters for Alaska and New Jersey in FY2024, as their official PER diverged too greatly from what could be replicated using the public use data. Finally, I exclude Alaska, Rhode Island, and the District of Columbia for 2022 quarter 3, as they were missing most or all months in that quarter. The resulting state-quarter level dataset contains 601 state-quarters, from 3 fiscal years across 49 states plus DC and the Virgin Islands.

Case level descriptive statistics for eligible elderly and non-elderly households, shown in Table 1, indicate that these groups differ greatly in their household and program characteristics. Non-elderly households were much more likely to have payment errors, and their mean dollars paid in error was higher. On average, non-elderly households also received higher benefits, possibly due to their larger household size, and were more likely to have earned income. About 30% of non-elderly households had at least one able-bodied working-age adult without dependents (ABAWD) who was subject to work requirements. While the elderly households rarely had earned income, almost all had unearned income. The elderly group was typically assigned to a much longer certification period, with their average time between certification and observation in the QC being twice as long as that of the non-elderly.

[7] FNS significantly revised the criteria for classifying payment errors in 2021 (Rosenbaum and Bergh 2023). Because of this, post-2021 payment errors may constitute a fundamentally different measure from pre-2021 payment errors. For this reason, I restrict my period of analysis to after the pandemic.

[8] I drop observations for FY2022 and FY2023 for Delaware because it was missing a large proportion of data and did not comply with the federal QC requirements, making its PER less comparable (Leftin et al. 2025). I drop observations in Delaware for FY2024 for the sake of consistency. Guam had an extremely small number of QC cases (fewer than 50) for most quarters in the years studied. I drop Guam from the state-quarter data as this would potentially render quarterly aggregations imprecise and unrepresentative. I drop Guam from the case level data for the sake of consistency.

Table 1: Descriptive Statistics by Group for Eligible Cases in QC Sample (FY2022-2024)

	Elderly		Non-Elderly	
	mean	sd	mean	sd
Cases With Payment Errors	0.09	0.29	0.13	0.34
Payment Error Amount ($)*	12.41	45.11	27.42	91.54
Benefit Amount ($)*	171.12	112.79	489.70	316.34
Recertified in Qtr. Observed	0.13	0.34	0.19	0.39
Months Since Cert.	8.80	10.83	4.13	8.06
Assigned Cert. Period	21.81	12.24	10.31	6.81
Assigned to Simplified Reporting	0.59	0.49	0.82	0.38
Had Earned Income	0.06	0.23	0.43	0.50
Had Unearned Income	0.94	0.23	0.37	0.48
TANF	0.00	0.03	0.05	0.21
HH Size	1.07	0.26	2.52	1.61
Female Head of HH	0.59	0.49	0.71	0.45
White Head of HH**	0.57	0.50	0.50	0.50
Black Head of HH**	0.21	0.41	0.25	0.43
Latino/Hispanic Head of HH**	0.07	0.25	0.09	0.29
Has ABAWD	0.00	0.01	0.30	0.46
Pct. of Cases Recertifying (lag)	0.17	0.08	0.17	0.08
Avg. Non-Elderly Cert. Period (lag)	10.52	3.07		
Avg. Elderly Cert. Period (lag)			21.63	7.89
Frac. Non-Elderly Recert. Per Q. (lag)	0.32	0.11		
Frac. Elderly Recert. Per Q. (lag)			0.16	0.06
Unemployment Rate (lag)	0.04	0.01	0.04	0.01
ESAP (lag)	0.35	0.48	0.39	0.49
Observations	45,383		69,732	

*Dollar amounts are inflation adjusted based on SNAP allotments for FY2024.

**USDA recommends against tabulating race/ethnicity variables due to missing data.

Lack of data is a key challenge in studying PER. Unfortunately, the public-use version of the QC is primarily intended to be used as a snapshot of the eligible SNAP caseload. Thus, cases determined to be ineligible by QC reviewers are excluded from the public use data (Leftin et al. 2024). This makes it difficult to use the public use data to study PER, as these ineligible cases make up the vast majority of dollar payment errors (about 75.4% of payment errors in FY2023).[9] For this reason, I restrict my estimand to the types of errors fully visible in the QC: underpayments and overpayments to eligible households.

In order to reflect the methodology of the official PER calculation, I define a SNAP case as having a payment error if the dollar amount by which its benefits were in error was greater than the USDA's tolerance threshold for that fiscal year. For example, eligible cases from fiscal year 2024 are considered to have a payment error if their benefit amount was off by more than $56 (Leftin et al. 2026). From this, I calculate separate observable over/underpayment error rates, and overall PER at the state-quarter level for each group. For each focal group g I construct a PER measure:

[9]According to the QC technical documentation for FY2023 (Table II.3) (Leftin et al. 2025), an average of $661 million in benefits were issued to ineligible cases each month, which totals $7,931.6 million for FY2023. Page 15 of the FY2023 QC annual report (FNS 2025) shows that total overpayments and underpayments were $10,515.9 million for that year. Dividing the former number by the latter indicates that benefits to ineligible households constitute very roughly 75.4% of payment errors in FY2023.

$$\text{Underpayment Error Rate}_{sqg} = \frac{\text{Total Observed Underpayments in Group}_{sqg}}{\text{Total Observed Allotments in Group}_{sqg}}$$

$$\text{Overpayment Error Rate}_{sqg} = \frac{\text{Total Observed Overpayments in Group}_{sqg}}{\text{Total Observed Allotments in Group}_{sqg}}$$

$$\text{PER}_{sqg} = \text{Underpayment Error Rate}_{sqg} + \text{Overpayment Error Rate}_{sqg}$$

Among eligible cases in group g, in state s, and quarter q, this represents the fraction of benefits that were paid in error. It only directly provides information on the observed types of errors, not the overall payment error rates within these groups, which would include payments to ineligible households. This is a serious limitation, given that such cases make up the bulk of dollar errors. However, ineligible cases make up a much smaller share of the cases with payment errors, constituting only 25.3% of errors in the QC data from the states and years studied[10]. Thus, I construct a group level Case Error Rate (CER) in order to better estimate the effects of administrative spillover on the probability of payment errors. This measures the fraction of observed cases in each group which had a payment error.

$$\text{Underpayment Case Error Rate}_{sqg} = \frac{\text{N. Observed Cases in Group with Underpayments}_{sqg}}{\text{N. Observed Cases in Group in QC Dataset}_{sqg}}$$

$$\text{Overpayment Case Error Rate}_{sqg} = \frac{\text{N. Observed Cases in Group with Overpayments}_{sqg}}{\text{N. Observed Cases in Group in QC Dataset}_{sqg}}$$

$$\text{CER}_{sqg} = \text{Underpayment Case Error Rate}_{sqg} + \text{Overpayment Case Error Rate}_{sqg}$$

Ideally I would be able to use variation in state policies in order to identify variation in the share of cases recertifying. However, there exists no dataset which comprehensively tracks such policies over time[11]. Instead, I use the average certification period lengths observed in the QC data.

A lack of sufficiently detailed and publicly available measures of administrative workload within SNAP agencies poses a further challenge to assessing the administrative workload hypothesis. Instead, I use the fraction of cases recertifying in a given quarter as a proxy for workload. Certification and recertification of SNAP cases make up the primary work performed by SNAP agencies and constitute the bulk of their operational spending (Geller et al. 2019). Thus, variation in the share of cases facing recertification at a given time represents variation in the work of performing recertification interviews and processing the related paperwork. The fraction of cases facing recertification is mechanically determined by the frequency with which cases are required to recertify, and is thus driven by state and federal policies regarding which certification period lengths are assigned to whom.

For my unemployment rate control, I use the unadjusted state level unemployment rate series from the Bureau of Labor Statistics' Local Area Unemployment Statistics (LAUS). I obtained the LAUS data for

[10]Excluding Delaware and Guam, the public use QC data for FY2022-2024 contained 14,595 payment errors. The QC documentation indicates a further 4,941 errors from payments to ineligible cases. This works out to 25.29%.

[11]The USDA's SNAP Policy Database does contain variables tracking certification periods. However, these variables are just tabulations of the certification periods observed in the QC data, calculated based on the trailing 6 months. I decided that it was better to use the QC data to construct certification period variables that are better tuned to my identification strategy. Additionally, the database does not contain any observations after 2020, and thus excludes the years studied in this paper.

the Virgin Islands from the U.S. Virgin Islands Department of Labor. I use the unemployment rate for the middle month of the relevant quarter (February, May, August, November).

I obtained the state implementation dates for the Elderly Simplified Application Project (ESAP) from a combination of news articles, legislative records, and other sources (see Appendix C for more details). Within my period of study, I was only able to obtain an approximate ESAP implementation date for the District of Columbia.

5 Methods

I estimate the causal effect of administrative workload on payment errors among eligible cases in each focal group (elderly vs non-elderly) using IV regressions based on the certification periods of an alternate group, disjoint from the focal group (see Conceptual Framework section). For the sake of clarity, I shall describe the estimation in terms of the non-elderly as the focal group and the elderly as the alternate group, though the explanation will apply equally to both focal groups. The endogenous regressor of interest for all regressions is the fraction of SNAP cases that recertified in a given state-quarter. This represents the overall administrative workload faced by state agencies, and is intended to capture the strain that administrators face as they certify and monitor non-elderly cases (focal group).

I cannot directly use the average certification period among households where all members were elderly/disabled (alternate group) as my excluded instrument because this would cause misspecification. As I show in Figure 3 in Appendix A, the unconditional first stage relationships appear to be nonlinear. This nonlinearity is primarily mechanical, i.e., arithmetically, increasing elderly certification periods from 24 to 36 months will have less of an effect on the share of cases recertifying than increasing it from 12 to 24 months, all else equal. While a misspecified first stage would not necessarily bias my IV estimates, it would reduce their precision and mean that the LATE recovered by my models would more heavily weight some regions of variation than others. To avoid these complications, I construct linearized instruments as:

$$C_{g^{-1}} = \frac{3}{\text{Alternate Group Avg. Certification Period in Months}_{g^{-1}}}$$

This transformation is monotone for strictly positive certification periods. Thus, for the non-elderly focal group, instead of using the average certification period for the elderly as an instrument, my instrument is the average fraction of elderly cases who will be up to recertify per quarter. However, in terms of data, it is simply a transformed version of average certification periods. As shown in Figure 4, this approach produces an approximately linear first stage relationship.

The outcome variables consist of the measures of payment accuracy described in the previous section. SNAP cases are only observed in the QC for a single reference month. The case level outcomes are observed in the "present" represented by this reference month. Thus, for the state-quarter level dataset, the outcome variables are the $\widehat{CER}_{gsq}$ and $\widehat{PER}_{gsq}$ among the eligible cases in group g which were observed in state s in quarter q. For the case level dataset, the outcomes are a binary indicator $Error_{igsq}$ that case i from group g had a payment error, and the inflation adjusted dollar amount $Amount_{igsq}$ of those errors.

Errors are observed in the present, during the month that a case is audited and appears in the QC. However, most errors occur prior to this, primarily during certification. Indeed, 68.13% of the payment errors in my dataset occurred during certification or before certification (meaning that the certification process failed to correct the error)[12]. Therefore, it is better to use the explanatory variables from the time period in which cases certified, not the time period in which outcomes were observed. Thus, for the state-quarter regressions I lag the instrument, endogenous regressor, and all other covariates to the quarter in which the cases in a group were certified.

To rephrase this, for all regressions, I measure errors at the time a case appears in the QC and measure the workload and instrument during the quarter in which a household certified. For example, my state-quarter endogenous regressor F_{gsq} is the average fraction of SNAP cases that recertified in state s during all the quarters that the cases in group g (who were observed in quarter q) were certified. Thus, for cases observed in a given quarter, I average the fraction recertifying in the certification quarter among all of them. For the sake of illustration, consider a non-elderly case observed in California in quarter 1 of 2023, but certified in quarter 2 of 2022. For this case I would calculate the fraction of cases in California who recertified in quarter 2 of 2022. I then aggregate this to the state-quarter by finding this fraction for all non-elderly cases observed in California in quarter 1 of 2023, regardless of when they certified, and calculating F_{gsq} as the average of these fractions. Unless stated otherwise, this aggregation procedure is used for all other state-quarter level regressors.

The state-quarter level first-stage regression, shown below, estimates the effect of the lagged average fraction of alternate group cases recertifying per quarter $C_{g^{-1}sq}$ on the lagged fraction of cases recertifying F_{gsq}.

$$F_{gsq} = \alpha_1 + \beta_1 C_{g^{-1}sq} + \delta_1 G_{gsq} + \gamma_1 Policy_{gsq} + \eta_1 X_{gsq} + \lambda_s + \tau_q + \epsilon_{gsq}$$

Here, λ_s and τ_q are state and quarter fixed effects, and $Policy_{gsq}$ represents a set of policy controls discussed below. X_{gsq} contains controls for the lagged unemployment rate and the fraction of current cases in group g that had a female head of household[13].

States may decide to simultaneously lengthen or shorten the certification periods for both groups. In this scenario, the certification period for the non-elderly becomes correlated with the instrument. Meanwhile, the effect of their own certification period would affect the payment accuracy among the non-elderly through the verification and caseload composition channels. This would violate the exclusion restriction, biasing the first stage away from 0 and biasing the reduced form towards 0. In order to avoid this, I control for G_{gsq}, the average certification period among active cases in group g who were observed in state s and quarter q. In other words, the linearized average certification period for the elderly is the instrument and the average certification period for the non-elderly is a control.

[12]Individual cases may contain multiple errors which might occur at different times. Among cases with payment errors: 57.92% had all errors occur during certification, 8.88% had all errors occur before certification, and 1.33% had all errors occur before and during certification.

[13]Following Fannin (2025), I do not control for racial/ethnic demographics because the QC technical documentation advises against using them due to a high rate of non-response.

The second stage regression is shown below. Y_{gsq} represents the CER and PER outcome variables.

$$Y_{gsq} = \beta_2 \hat{F}_{gsq} + \delta_2 G_{gsq} + \gamma_2 Policy_{gsq} + \eta_2 X_{gsq} + \lambda_s + \tau_q + e_{gsq}$$

The relevance assumption is that variation in elderly certification periods induces meaningful variation in the fraction of cases recertifying, and the exclusion restriction assumption is that this variation is exogenous to the potential payment accuracy of the non-elderly. Policy endogeneity is likely the most serious threat to this assumption. A state's decision to shorten or lengthen assigned certification periods may be part of a larger package of policy changes which could independently affect PER, recertification rate, or both. Depending on the nature of the policy, this could violate the exclusion restriction or independence assumptions. For example, if a state desires to expand access to SNAP, it might simultaneously lengthen certification periods for the elderly while reducing verification requirements for the non-elderly. The former might decrease non-elderly errors and represents the "good" variation, while the latter might increase them, biasing the reduced form towards 0. Additionally, states with high PER may adopt policies aimed at reducing it, introducing bias from reverse causation. In order to address these threats, I control for several state policies.

The Elderly Simplified Application Project (ESAP) is a bundle of policies that states have the option to adopt in order to ease program participation among households with no earned income and where all members are elderly (or, in some states, disabled). These policies include lengthening these households' maximum allowable certification periods from 24 to 36 months, as well as waiving recertification interviews and certain verification paperwork. In regressions focusing on the non-elderly, the certification period change would cause variation in the instrument. The latter policies might reduce administrative workload by themselves, thus impacting non-elderly PER through a mechanism other than the share of cases recertifying. While this could technically be considered an administrative spillover, it would not be an administrative spillover caused by the variable of interest, and thus would bias the reduced form away from zero[14]. In order to avoid this exclusion restriction violation, I include a lagged binary control for state ESAP adoption in the regressions for which the non-elderly is the focal group. Controlling for ESAP risks potentially absorbing some of the "good" variation in the first stage, biasing the instrument's coefficient towards 0. However, as I explain in my discussion section, this effect does not appear to be large. I do not control for ESAP in regressions focused on the elderly, as it doesn't theoretically violate exclusion for this group.

Depending on their certification period, SNAP cases are usually required to perform some form of interim reporting. This can take a variety of forms depending on the state and type of case, such as a requirement to fill out paperwork halfway through the certification period, or a requirement to report changes to income or household composition. Reporting regimes are often inextricable from certification periods. For example, a requirement to report income to the state agency every 6 months is necessarily only applicable to cases with certification periods longer than 6 months. This likely means that state reporting policies are correlated with my instrument. Additionally, many states have adopted a policy of Simplified Reporting, which may reduce payment errors through several mechanisms, including by simplifying administration and reducing the number of things that are counted as errors in the QC (Trippe et al. 2004). Thus, when estimating payment errors for the non-elderly, I control for the lagged fraction of elderly cases which were subject to

[14]Similar arguments could be made about the SSI Combined Application Project (SSI-CAP). However, I do not control for SSI-CAP as it greatly increases multicollinearity without meaningfully changing the coefficients of interest.

simplified reporting (and vice versa).

Lee and Porter (2026) argue that the possibility of having a weak instrument can never be definitively ruled out, and that therefore it is necessary to use statistical inference methods that are "robust to weak instruments". Thus, in addition to standard t-statistic based statistical inference, I evaluate my IV estimates based on their Anderson-Rubin statistic and its associated p-value[15]. Additionally, I estimate all regressions with robust standard errors, clustered at the state level.

6 Results

The results of the state-quarter level regressions are shown in Table 2 and Table 3. The regressions include observations for 51 states and territories across the 12 quarters of FY2022-2024, with state and quarter fixed effects included in all regressions. For both the elderly and non-elderly groups, the first stage relationship between the instrument and the fraction of cases recertifying (column 1) is significant at the 0.1% level and is in the expected direction. The instruments in row 1 are the average fraction of cases in the alternate category who will need to recertify per quarter, based on their observed certification periods. A one standard deviation increase in these instruments would increase the fraction of all cases recertifying per quarter by 7.1 and 3.5 percentage points, for the elderly and non-elderly regressions respectively, relative to means of 16.9 and 16.6%. For both regressions, the instrument has a Kleibergen-Paap rk Wald F statistic[16] (which I shall refer to as the F statistic) well above 30.

The underidentification test for the first stage for the non-elderly focal group (Table 3 Column 1) has a Kleibergen-Paap rk LM statistic of 3.336 (p=0.0678). This indicates that I can only weakly reject the possibility that this first stage is underidentified at the 10% significance level. In this context, underidentification would mean that my first stage matrix is not full rank and that my instrument does not explain sufficient linearly independent variation in my endogenous regressor. This is somewhat surprising given that the coefficient on the instrument for the non-elderly group is large, significant, and possesses a large F statistic. The potential underidentification is likely caused by a high degree of collinearity between the instrument and the state fixed effects, with the non-elderly focal group's instrument possessing a VIF of 26.45 in the first stage. Much of the variation in my instrument is between states, and thus it is possible that there was insufficient change to certification periods within states during the three years studied. As I shall show in the Discussion section, clustering at the state level may also contribute to this. Whichever factor may be responsible, this lack of strong identification limits confidence in my non-elderly state-quarter level results.

For the elderly IV regressions (columns 3 and 5 in Table 2), the effects of the share of cases recertifying are small and not statistically significant. This is in spite of the fact that the OLS estimates in Columns 2 and 4 are large and positive.

The IV effects (columns 3 and 5 in Table 3) for the non-elderly focal group are large for both outcomes, but only the effect on CER is statistically significant ($p < .05$). The coefficients of interest indicate that,

[15]I obtain my AR statistic by computing the F statistic for my reduced form regressions, as these are equivalent in the just-identified case.

[16]I use the Kleibergen-Paap rk Wald F statistic because it is most appropriate for my clustered robust errors.

if the fraction of cases recertifying per quarter increased from 0 to 1, then the non-elderly Case Error Rate (CER) would increase by 37.8 percentage points, and the non-elderly PER would increase by 19.8 percentage points. On a more grounded level, a one standard deviation increase in the fraction of cases recertifying per quarter (7.2 pp) would cause the fraction of eligible non-elderly cases with errors to increase by 2.7 percentage points relative to the mean of 12.9%, an increase of about 21%. The same increase in recertifications causes the fraction of eligible non-elderly benefits that are paid in error to increase by about 1.4 percentage points relative to a mean of 5.6%, an increase of about 25.1%. Though this effect on PER is not statistically significant, it is certainly economically significant.

While both non-elderly estimates are quite imprecise and could be better identified, they would seem to align with the administrative spillover hypothesis. In particular, the CER result provides evidence that certifying elderly/disabled SNAP households for shorter periods can increase the workload faced by state agencies, leading to worsened payment accuracy among other groups of recipients. However, this is undermined by the Anderson-Rubin statistic. Based on its weak-instrument-robust p-value (p=0.063), the effect on CER is only weakly significant at 10%. If my instrument is indeed weak, then this lowers the probability that my result represents a significant relationship between certification workload and non-elderly payment errors.

Depending on the strength of my instrument, the first stage and IV results suggest that decreasing the certification period assigned to elderly/disabled households from 24 to 12 months would increase the instrument (average share of elderly recertifying) from 12.5% to 25%. This would increase the quarterly share of all cases recertifying by about 6.8 percentage points, which would increase the CER and PER among eligible non-elderly households by about 2.6 and 1.3 percentage points respectively. This effect is economically significant, given that the average quarterly CER and PER for this group were 12.9% and 5.6%.

Several of the controls for the non-elderly regressions are worth noting for the sake of context. Longer average certification periods among the non-elderly have the expected relationships, mechanically reducing the fraction of cases recertifying ($p < .001$) in the first stage (column 1), while not being significantly associated with higher payment errors in the second stage (columns 3 and 5). This latter relationship is not in line with what we would expect from the verification channel, as estimated by past research (Kabbani and Wilde 2003, Mills et al. 2004). The coefficients on ESAP are also surprising. State adoption of ESAP should mechanically reduce the frequency of recertification, but the first stage does not find a meaningful association, possibly due to high collinearity with the instrument. More puzzlingly, ESAP is significantly and precisely associated with higher payment errors among the non-elderly in the IV regressions. This runs contrary to the expectation that some of ESAP's simplifications would reduce administrative workload and thus payment errors.

Multicollinearity is a prominent feature of my results. While no regression had a mean VIF above 10, key variables were typically collinear. The instrument had VIFs of 33.26 and 26.45 for the elderly and non-elderly regressions, respectively. The instruments' collinearity seems to be primarily attributable to the state fixed effects, dropping by more than half when these effects are excluded from estimation. For the non-elderly regression, the ESAP control had a VIF of 11.77. Finally, the control for a group's own certification period (Avg. Elderly Cert. Period and Avg. Non-Elderly Cert. Period) had a VIF over 10 in all regressions.

Table 2: Effect of Administrative Workload on SNAP Payment Accuracy for the Elderly/Disabled (State-Quarter Level)

	Pct. Recert. in Cert. Q.	Case Error Rate		Payment Error Rate	
	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)	(5)
	1st	OLS	IV	OLS	IV
Frac. Non-Elderly Recert. Per Q. (lag)	0.638***				
	(0.0453)				
Pct. of Cases Recertifying (lag)		0.184*	0.0581	0.159*	0.135
		(0.0863)	(0.118)	(0.0703)	(0.119)
Avg. Elderly Cert. Period	-0.000222	0.000966	0.000716	0.000328	0.000281
	(0.000468)	(0.000854)	(0.000864)	(0.000972)	(0.000928)
Non-Elderly Simplified Reporting Pct. (lag)	0.0111	0.00121	0.00299	0.00188	0.00222
	(0.0148)	(0.0156)	(0.0165)	(0.0125)	(0.0121)
Unemployment rate (lag)	0.141	-0.511	-0.526	-0.169	-0.171
	(0.436)	(0.440)	(0.456)	(0.424)	(0.419)
Constant	-0.0536	0.0473		0.0374	
	(0.0337)	(0.0410)		(0.0315)	
Observations	601	601	601	601	601
KP rk Wald F-stat (excluded instrument)	199.2				
Underidentification Test p-value	0.0305				
Anderson-Rubin Stat. (AR)			0.228		1.217
AR p-value			0.635		0.275

Robust standard errors, clustered at the state level, are reported in parentheses.

* $p < 0.05$, ** $p < 0.01$, *** $p < 0.001$

Table 3: Effect of Administrative Workload on SNAP Payment Accuracy for the Non-Elderly (State-Quarter Level)

	Pct. Recert. in Cert. Q.	Case Error Rate		Payment Error Rate	
	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)	(5)
	1st	OLS	IV	OLS	IV
Frac. Elderly Recert. Per Q. (lag)	0.541***				
	(0.0849)				
Pct. of Cases Recertifying (lag)		0.0804	0.378*	0.0756*	0.198
		(0.0627)	(0.191)	(0.0310)	(0.150)
Avg. Non-Elderly Cert. Period	-0.00833***	-0.000102	0.00300	0.000771	0.00205
	(0.00114)	(0.00147)	(0.00281)	(0.000781)	(0.00188)
Elderly Simplified Reporting Pct. (lag)	-0.0137	0.00309	0.00583	-0.00240	-0.00127
	(0.0128)	(0.00729)	(0.00895)	(0.00425)	(0.00462)
ESAP (lag)	-0.00806	0.0152*	0.0244**	0.0106**	0.0144*
	(0.00994)	(0.00660)	(0.00876)	(0.00368)	(0.00595)
Unemployment rate (lag)	0.420	-0.629	-0.728	-0.576	-0.617*
	(0.417)	(0.469)	(0.391)	(0.324)	(0.295)
Constant	0.113**	0.105**		0.0400	
	(0.0382)	(0.0371)		(0.0233)	
Observations	601	601	601	601	601
KP rk Wald F-stat (excluded instrument)	40.78				
Underidentification Test p-value	0.0678				
Anderson-Rubin Stat. (AR)			3.610		1.471
AR p-value			0.0632		0.231

Robust standard errors, clustered at the state level, are reported in parentheses.

* $p < 0.05$, ** $p < 0.01$, *** $p < 0.001$

7 Discussion and Robustness Checks

My regressions seem to indicate that administrative workload causes higher payment errors among SNAP households where not all members are elderly or disabled. This would provide evidence that requiring more frequent recertification can act to increase a state's errors to the extent that this would increase workload. However, my primary result has lower significance under weak instrument robust methods, and we can only weakly reject the possibility that it is underidentified. Even if we were to suppose that this result is correct, there are several important nuances to its interpretation. Firstly, IV estimates are only significant for the share of cases with errors (CER), and not the actual Payment Error Rate. Additionally, as I discussed in my Conceptual Framework section, administrative spillovers are only one way in which changing a state's certification period might affect their payment errors. The net treatment effect of shortening certification periods on CER and PER might still be negative if the other mechanisms dominate. Finally, my results only estimate the effect of recertification on payment errors among eligible cases, as the public QC data does not allow me to directly observe SNAP payments to ineligible cases. This limits how much they can tell us about the total amount of dollars paid in error, as eligible cases only account for about 25% of total PER.

If workload increases these errors then it seems plausible that ineligible errors would be similarly affected. If an increased workload would cause a caseworker to mistakenly allot too many benefits to an eligible household more often, then we might expect that they would more often award benefits to ineligible households. In particular, my estimates for CER are likely informative about the overall occurrence of payment errors, as roughly 71% of cases with errors in FY2023 were eligible[17]. For this reason, I focus my discussion and robustness checks on CER and the case level probability of errors. Future research will require access to more detailed QC data in order to determine the impact of administrative workload on ineligible payment errors.

I do not find evidence that administrative workload increases payment errors among the roughly 40% of SNAP households where all members are either elderly or disabled. There are several possible explanations for this discrepancy. It is plausible that the treatment effect is genuinely heterogeneous, and that administrative workload matters for the non-elderly but not for the elderly. Compared to their non-elderly counterparts, elderly SNAP cases may be simpler to administer, with less that can go wrong during certification. As shown in Table 1, eligible non-elderly households are more likely to have a payment error, possibly because they are more likely to have earned income.

Lack of identifying variation in the instrument might also explain the different results between groups, as the average certification period varied a lot more for the elderly than it did for the non-elderly. Among elderly cases in my regression sample, the average non-elderly certification period in their month of certification had a standard deviation of only 3.1 months, while for the non-elderly cases the analogous figure is 7.9 months. Thus, it is possible that the elderly may be affected by administrative spillovers, but no such spillovers happened to occur during the period of analysis.

The control for each group's own certification period, intended as a control for policies affecting the certification periods of both groups, is collinear in all primary specifications, though not collinear with the instrument. To examine the role of this control in shaping outcomes, I estimate my primary results for CER using an alternative version of this control. Instead of controlling for average assigned certification period, the regressions shown in columns 1 and 2 of Table 6 use a measure of average time elapsed since certification among a group, which has a VIF below 10 in all specifications. The IV effect on the elderly remains small and insignificant. The point estimate for the non-elderly shrinks by about a quarter but retains its significance, and this significance is robust even if the instrument is weak (AR $p < .05$). While the F statistic improves, the underidentification issue becomes worse. Experimentation finds that this is almost entirely attributable to removal of the original own-certification control, rather than the addition of the alternate one. This result indicates that properly accounting for the certification periods of both groups is essential to identifying the first stage relationships.

[17]This is based on the number of errors in my dataset and the number of ineligible cases recorded in the QC documentation.

Table 4: Effect of Administrative Workload on SNAP Payment Accuracy for the Elderly/Disabled (Case Level)

	Pct. Recert. in Cert. Q.	Prob. of Payment Error		Amount of Payment Error	
	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)	(5)
	1st	OLS	IV	OLS	IV
Frac. Non-Elderly Recert. Per Q. (lag)	0.505***				
	(0.0552)				
Pct. of Cases Recertifying (lag)		0.0227	0.0839	-0.425	11.77
		(0.0365)	(0.0927)	(5.243)	(13.82)
Avg. Elderly Cert. Period	-0.00120**	0.000193	0.000353	0.0748	0.107
	(0.000364)	(0.000605)	(0.000673)	(0.0903)	(0.102)
Non-Elderly Simplified Reporting Pct. (lag)	0.000858	-0.00935	-0.00929	-1.219	-1.208
	(0.00572)	(0.00502)	(0.00490)	(0.743)	(0.734)
Unemployment Rate (lag)	-0.189	0.145	0.167	53.05	57.51
	(0.328)	(0.258)	(0.255)	(44.16)	(43.74)
HH Size	0.000370	0.0493***	0.0493***	12.23***	12.22***
	(0.000765)	(0.00818)	(0.00811)	(1.689)	(1.675)
Working Poor	-0.000370	0.127***	0.127***	25.72***	25.72***
	(0.00100)	(0.0145)	(0.0143)	(3.149)	(3.119)
Cert. During Pandemic	0.0224**	-0.00568	-0.00680	-0.924	-1.147
	(0.00720)	(0.00462)	(0.00461)	(0.619)	(0.644)
Constant	0.0355	0.00343		-6.598*	
	(0.0237)	(0.0154)		(2.677)	
Observations	45383	45383	45383	45383	45383
KP rk Wald F-stat (excluded instrument)	83.70				
Underidentification Test p-value	0.00694				
Anderson-Rubin Stat. (AR)			0.823		0.738
AR p-value			0.369		0.394

Robust standard errors, clustered at the state level, are reported in parentheses.

* $p < 0.05$, ** $p < 0.01$, *** $p < 0.001$

Table 5: Effect of Administrative Workload on SNAP Payment Accuracy for the Non-Elderly (Case Level)

	Pct. Recert. in Cert. Q.	Prob. of Payment Error		Amount of Payment Error	
	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)	(5)
	1st	OLS	IV	OLS	IV
Frac. Elderly Recert. Per Q. (lag)	0.532***				
	(0.0663)				
Pct. of Cases Recertifying (lag)		0.00217	0.369	8.005	66.97
		(0.0348)	(0.212)	(8.827)	(64.67)
Avg. Non-Elderly Cert. Period	-0.00886***	-0.000878	0.00335	0.146	0.827
	(0.00109)	(0.00178)	(0.00289)	(0.410)	(0.740)
ESAP (lag)	-0.00928	-0.0167*	-0.00668	-2.774	-1.158
	(0.00857)	(0.00650)	(0.00892)	(1.837)	(2.795)
HH Size	-0.0000107	0.0175***	0.0176***	5.807***	5.810***
	(0.000115)	(0.00151)	(0.00151)	(0.486)	(0.483)
Elderly Simplified Reporting Pct. (lag)	-0.00811	-0.00530	-0.00283	-1.403	-1.006
	(0.00756)	(0.00545)	(0.00594)	(1.393)	(1.544)
Unemployment Rate (lag)	-0.428	-0.0741	0.110	29.54	59.23
	(0.285)	(0.248)	(0.263)	(75.69)	(69.63)
Working Poor	0.000304	0.141***	0.141***	32.66***	32.64***
	(0.000320)	(0.00917)	(0.00910)	(2.866)	(2.838)
Cert. During Pandemic	0.0173	0.0167**	0.0109	3.946**	3.011*
	(0.00947)	(0.00561)	(0.00725)	(1.458)	(1.487)
Constant	0.195***	-0.0122		-14.67*	
	(0.0212)	(0.0270)		(6.607)	
Observations	69732	69732	69732	69732	69732
KP rk Wald F-stat (excluded instrument)	64.55				
Underidentification Test p-value	0.0228				
Anderson-Rubin Stat. (AR)			3.294		1.074
AR p-value			0.0755		0.305

Robust standard errors, clustered at the state level, are reported in parentheses.

* $p < 0.05$, ** $p < 0.01$, *** $p < 0.001$

In order to test whether my results are robust to disaggregation, I re-estimate my primary regressions using the case level data from which state-quarter level aggregates were constructed. The outcome variables are a binary indicator for whether an individual case has a payment error, analogous to CER, and a case's dollars paid in error[18]. The results for these case-level regressions are shown in Table 4 and Table 5. All models are identified, though most estimates are fairly imprecise, in spite of the much larger sample sizes. Just as with the state-quarter level regressions, the case level first stage relationships between the instrument and the fraction of all cases recertifying (column 1) are significant at the 0.1% level and positive, with F statistics over 30 for both focal groups. They indicate that increasing the share of elderly or non-elderly cases recertifying per quarter by 10 percentage points would increase the fraction of all cases recertifying per quarter by 5.1 and 5.3 percentage points respectively, relative to means of about 17%.

The IV estimates for the non-elderly households were large but imprecise. Taken at face value, the coefficient of interest in Table 5 column 3 would indicate that increasing the fraction of cases recertifying by 1 standard deviation would increase the probability of an error by about 3 percentage points, or 23.1% relative to the mean probability of 12.9%. While this coefficient is only weakly significant at 10%, its magnitude and interpretation are very close to those of its counterpart in the non-elderly state-quarter regressions. Just as with the state-quarter level regressions, weak instrument robust p-values only yield a 10% significance. The coefficient of interest in column 5 suggests that a similar increase would increase the average payment error amount per case by $5.42, relative to a mean of $27.72, though this lacks any statistical significance. The elderly IV results were much smaller, and statistically insignificant, but ran in the same direction as their state-quarter level counterparts.

The Elderly Simplified Application Project is a key variable for the regressions where the non-elderly are the focal group. It is a necessary control for a potential exclusion restriction violation (see my Methods section). However, the policy is likely one of the primary causes of variation in my instrument. Thus my ESAP control is highly collinear with my instrument and likely absorbs some of the desirable identifying variation. To examine how ESAP affects my results, I perform several robustness checks shown in Table 7.

I show my primary specifications for the sake of comparison in Column 1, while Column 2 shows the same regression without the binary ESAP control. In this specification, the coefficient of interest collapses to less than half its size, losing any significance, while precision is minimally affected. The VIF for the instrument falls from 26.5 to 20.8. The F statistic increases and the first stage coefficient of interest (not shown) is minimally affected, going from about .54 to .58. Thus, the changes to the coefficients of interest are primarily due to a reduction in the reduced form relationship between the average percent of elderly recertifying and the rate at which payment errors occur, with the reduced form coefficient decreasing by more than half. Inclusion of the ESAP control was originally motivated by a concern that the reduced form effect would otherwise be biased upwards. However, the decrease in the reduced form coefficient when the ESAP control is removed is the opposite of what we would expect to observe if such a bias existed. It is unclear if this means that excluding ESAP biases results in the other direction.

To further investigate the impact of ESAP, I estimate my results in Column 3 of Table 7 with a linear

[18]Dollar amounts are adjusted to FY2024 dollars. I do this by calculating a Thrifty Food Plan deflator based on the maximum allotment for a household of 1 for each fiscal year.

time trend representing the number of quarters since a state has adopted ESAP. Compared to the primary specifications, the IV effect decreases by about a third, losing significance. This occurs due to the reduced form effect shrinking slightly while the first stage increases slightly. While the instruments' VIF scores improve relative to baseline, the ESAP time trend has a VIF of over 20 due to collinearity with the state fixed effects. Taken together, the regressions in Table 7 indicate that my results are highly sensitive to whether and how I account for ESAP. Future research on SNAP certification periods will need to investigate and account for the role played by ESAP in how certification periods relate to payment errors.

8 Conclusion

I find evidence that administrative workload can increase payment errors among certain types of eligible SNAP cases. This means that shorter certification periods can increase Case Error Rates to the extent that they increase the workload faced by state agencies. However, these results are not robust, with a number of empirical challenges that must be resolved before they can be taken as strong evidence of a relationship. My results do suggest that future researchers should question the centrality of the accuracy-access tradeoff, which has remained a focal point of the literature, despite the relative lack of evidence for its practical relevance to SNAP certification periods and PER.

These findings are relevant to states searching for strategies to reduce their PER in order to avoid the hefty financial penalties levied by the One Big Beautiful Bill Act. Adopting shorter certification periods in order to improve verification of participant information may be counterproductive if the increased workload from processing these recertifications leads administrators to make more mistakes. Further research is urgently needed in order to determine the net effect that shorter certification periods have on PER. While my results do not estimate this net effect, they suggest that states should be careful to consider how policy changes may affect their staff and their overall administrative capacity.

9 Works Cited

American Public Human Services Association. 2023. "Payment Error Rates: Understanding What They Are and How to Support SNAP Agencies in Reducing Them." Washington, DC: APHSA. https://aphsa.org/wp-content/uploads/2024/07/96c3eef9-9ae5-43f8-a2c1-6003e0851226.pdf.

Benvie, Catherine, Michael Ribar, John Knaus, Victoria Perez-Zetune, Katie Powell, Megan Worden, Polina Zvavitch, Olivia Iles, Patricia McGinn, and Elizabeth Weber. 2023. Supplemental Nutrition Assistance Program State Options Report, 15th ed. Prepared by Westat for U.S. Department of Agriculture, Food and Nutrition Service, Program Development Division, October 2023.

Bergh, Katie, and Dottie Rosenbaum. 2026. "Congressional Delay of SNAP Cost Shift Urgently Needed to Protect Food Assistance for Low-Income Families." Washington, DC: Center on Budget and Policy Priorities, January 8, 2026. https://www.cbpp.org/research/food-assistance/congressional-delay-of-snap-cost-shift-urgently-needed-to-protect-food.

Currie, Janet, and Jeffrey Grogger. 2001. "Explaining Recent Declines in Food Stamp Program Participation." Brookings-Wharton Papers on Urban Affairs: 203–44.

Fannin, W. Clay. 2025. "Can Reducing Administrative Burdens Increase Benefit Amounts? Evidence from SNAP Simplified Reporting." Applied Economic Perspectives and Policy 47 (3): 965–982. https://doi.org/10.1002/aepp.13508.

Feeding America. 2026. "H.R. 1 'One Big Beautiful Bill Act' FAQ." Last updated June 24, 2026. Chicago: Feeding America. https://www.feedingamerica.org.

Finkelstein, Amy, and Matthew J. Notowidigdo. 2019. "Take-Up and Targeting: Experimental Evidence from SNAP." Quarterly Journal of Economics 134 (3): 1505–1556.

Food and Nutrition Service. 2018. Supplemental Nutrition Assistance Program State Options Report, 14th ed. Options as of October 1, 2017. Washington, DC: U.S. Department of Agriculture, Program Development Division, May 31, 2018.

Food and Nutrition Service. 2021. "Supplemental Nutrition Assistance Program: Non-Discretionary Quality Control Provisions of the Agricultural Improvement Act of 2018." Interim Final Rule. 86 Fed. Reg. 44575 (August 13, 2021). https://www.fns.usda.gov/snap/fr-081321.

Food and Nutrition Service. 2022. SNAP Quality Control Review Handbook. FNS Handbook 310. Alexandria, VA: U.S. Department of Agriculture, Food and Nutrition Service, October 2021, through QC Policy Memo 22-02.

Food and Nutrition Service. 2023. "Provisions to Improve the Supplemental Nutrition Assistance Program's Quality Control System." Notice of Proposed Rulemaking. 88 Fed. Reg. 64756 (September 19, 2023). FNS-2020-0016. https://www.federalregister.gov/documents/2023/09/19/2023-20023/provisions-to-improve-the-supplemental-nutrition-assistance-programs-quality-control-system.

Food and Nutrition Service. 2025. Supplemental Nutrition Assistance Program (SNAP) Quality Control Annual Report Fiscal Year 2023. Washington, DC: United States Department of Agriculture. https://fns-prod.azureedge.us/sites/default/files/resource-files/snap-qc-annualreportfy23.pdf.

Food and Nutrition Service. 2026. "SNAP Quality Control—Payment Error Rates." Washington, DC: U.S. Department of Agriculture. Accessed August 2, 2026. https://www.fns.usda.gov/snap/qc/per.

Food and Nutrition Administration. 2026. "Supplemental Nutrition Assistance Program: Payment Error Rates, Fiscal Year 2025." Washington, DC: U.S. Department of Agriculture. June 24, 2026.

Food and Nutrition Service. 2026. "Supplemental Nutrition Assistance Program Participation and Costs." Washington, DC: U.S. Department of Agriculture. Data as of July 10, 2026. https://www.fns.usda.gov/pd/supplemen

nutrition-assistance-program-snap.

Food Research and Action Center. 2025. "Shifting the Burden: How the Recently Passed Budget Reconciliation Package Reshapes SNAP and Strains State Budgets." Washington, DC: FRAC, July 30, 2025. https://frac.org/blog/shifting-the-burden-how-the-recently-passed-budget-reconciliation-package-reshapes-snap-and-strains-state-budgets.

Fox, Ashley, Wei Feng, and Mackenzie Reynolds. 2023. "The Effect of Administrative Burden on State Safety-Net Participation: Evidence from Food Assistance, Cash Assistance, and Medicaid." Public Administration Review 83 (2): 367–384. https://doi.org/10.1111/puar.13497.

Geller, David, Julia Isaacs, Breno Braga, and Brice Zic. 2019. Exploring the Causes of State Variation in SNAP Administrative Costs. Washington, DC: Manhattan Strategy Group and Urban Institute, prepared for U.S. Department of Agriculture, Food and Nutrition Service, February 2019.

Giannella, Eric, Tatiana Homonoff, Gabriel Rino, and Jason Somerville. 2024. "Administrative Burden and Procedural Denials: Experimental Evidence from SNAP." American Economic Journal: Economic Policy 16 (4): 316–340.

Goodman-Bacon, Andrew. 2021. "Difference-in-Differences with Variation in Treatment Timing." Journal of Econometrics 225 (2): 254–277. https://doi.org/10.1016/j.jeconom.2021.03.014.

Gray, Colin. 2019. "Leaving Benefits on the Table: Evidence from SNAP." Journal of Public Economics 179: 104054.

Gray, Colin, Adam Leive, Elena Prager, Kelsey Pukelis, and Mark Zaki. 2023. "Employed in a SNAP? The Impact of Work Requirements on Program Participation and Labor Supply." American Economic Journal: Economic Policy 15(1): 306–341. https://doi.org/10.1257/pol.20200561

Hanratty, Maria J. 2006. "Has the Food Stamp Program Become More Accessible? Impacts of Recent Changes in Reporting Requirements and Asset Eligibility Limits." Journal of Policy Analysis and Management 25 (3): 603–621. https://doi.org/10.1002/pam.20193.

Herd, Pamela, and Donald P. Moynihan. 2019. Administrative Burden: Policymaking by Other Means. New York: Russell Sage Foundation. https://doi.org/10.7758/9781610448789.

Homonoff, Tatiana, and Jason Somerville. 2021. "Program Recertification Costs: Evidence from SNAP." American Economic Journal: Economic Policy 13 (4): 271–98.

Illinois Department of Human Services. 2025. "Impact of Federal SNAP Cuts on Illinois Families and Illinois' Response." PowerPoint presentation, October 15, 2025.

Johnson, Mike. 2025. "Transcript: House Speaker Mike Johnson on 'Face the Nation with Margaret Bren-

nan."' Interview by Margaret Brennan. Face the Nation. CBS News, May 25, 2025. https://www.cbsnews.com/news/mike-johnson-house-speaker-face-the-nation-transcript-05-25-2025/.

Kabbani, Nader S., and Parke E. Wilde. 2003. "Short Recertification Periods in the U.S. Food Stamp Program." Journal of Human Resources 38: 1112–38.

Kornfeld, Robert. 2002. Explaining Recent Trends in Food Stamp Program Caseloads. E-FAN-02-008. Washington, DC: U.S. Department of Agriculture, Economic Research Service.

Lee, David, and Jack Porter. 2026. "Correct (and Incorrect) Inference with a Single Instrumental Variable: Practical Takeaways from the Weak Instruments Literature." Journal of Economic Perspectives 40 (3): 193–212.

Leftin, Joshua, Mia Monkovic, Francisco Yang, Nima Rahimi, Andrew Wen, and Alma Vigil. 2024. Technical Documentation for the Fiscal Year 2022 Supplemental Nutrition Assistance Program Quality Control Database and the QC Minimodel. Final Report. Washington, DC: Mathematica, prepared for U.S. Department of Agriculture, Food and Nutrition Service, March 2024. Contract No. 12-3198-23-F-0016.

Leftin, Joshua, Mia Monkovic, Francisco Yang, John Carlo Maula, and Sam Bonelli. 2025. Technical Documentation for the Fiscal Year 2023 Supplemental Nutrition Assistance Program Quality Control Database and the QC Minimodel. Final Report. Washington, DC: Mathematica, prepared for U.S. Department of Agriculture, Food and Nutrition Service, April 2025. Contract No. 12-3198-23-F-0047.

Leftin, Joshua, Mia Monkovic, Francisco Yang, Sam Bonelli, and John Carlo Maula. 2026. Technical Documentation for the Fiscal Year 2024 Supplemental Nutrition Assistance Program Quality Control Database and the QC Minimodel. Final Report. Washington, DC: Mathematica, prepared for U.S. Department of Agriculture, Food and Nutrition Service, May 2026. Contract No. 12-3198-24-Q-0029.

Logan, Christopher, Ryan Kling, and William Rhodes. 2008. Food Stamp Program Certification Costs and Errors, 1989–2005. Final Report. Contractor and Cooperator Report No. 45. Washington, DC: Abt Associates Inc., prepared for U.S. Department of Agriculture, Economic Research Service, June 2008. Contract No. 59-5000-6-0078.

McConnell, Casey, Lindsey Morgan, Catherine Benvie, Michael Ribar, Olivia Iles, John Knaus, Victoria Perez-Zetune, Katie Powell, Polina Zvavitch, and Elizabeth Weber. 2024. Supplemental Nutrition Assistance Program State Options Report, 16th ed. Prepared by Westat for U.S. Department of Agriculture, Food and Nutrition Service, Program Development Division, June 2024.

McConnell, Casey, Lindsey Morgan, Michael Ribar, Catherine Benvie, Olivia Iles, John Knaus, Katie Powell, Megan Worden, Greeshma James, and Elizabeth Weber. 2025. Supplemental Nutrition Assistance Program State Options Report, 17th ed. Prepared by Westat for U.S. Department of Agriculture, Food and Nutrition Service, Program Development Division, December 2025.

Mills, Gregory, Diana Laliberty, and Carole Rodger. 2004. Food Stamp Certification Periods and Payment Accuracy: State Experience During 1997–2001. E-FAN-04-012. Washington, DC: U.S. Department of Agriculture, Economic Research Service.

Mills, Gregory, Tracy Vericker, Heather Koball, Kye Lippold, Laura Wheaton, and Sam Elkin. 2014. Understanding the Rates, Causes, and Costs of Churning in the Supplemental Nutrition Assistance Program. Alexandria, VA: Office of Policy Support, Food and Nutrition Service, United States Department of Agriculture.

Ratcliffe, Caroline, Signe-Mary McKernan, and Kenneth Finegold. 2008. "Effects of Food Stamp and TANF Policies on Food Stamp Receipt." Social Service Review 82 (2): 291–334. https://doi.org/10.1086/589707.

Ribar, David C., Marilyn Edelhoch, and Qiduan Liu. 2008. "Watching the Clocks: The Role of Food Stamp Recertification and TANF Time Limits in Caseload Dynamics." Journal of Human Resources 43 (1): 208–39.

Rosenbaum, Dottie, and Katie Bergh. 2023. "SNAP Includes an Extensive Payment Accuracy System." Washington, DC: Center on Budget and Policy Priorities. https://www.cbpp.org/sites/default/files/6-28-23fa.pdf.

Trippe, Carole, Liz Schott, Nancy Wemmerus, and Andrew Burwick. 2004. Simplified Reporting and Transitional Benefits in the Food Stamp Program—Case Studies of State Implementation. Final Report. E-FAN-04-003. Washington, DC: Mathematica Policy Research, Inc., prepared for U.S. Department of Agriculture, Economic Research Service, May 2004.

U.S. Department of Agriculture, Food and Nutrition Service. 2005. "The Effect of Simplified Reporting on Food Stamp Payment Accuracy." Accessed July 24, 2026. https://fns-prod.azureedge.us/sites/default/files/resource-files/snap-simplified-reporting-2005.pdf

U.S. Department of Agriculture, Food and Nutrition Administration. 2025. "SNAP Quality Control." Accessed August 1, 2026. https://www.fna.usda.gov/snap/qc.

U.S. Department of Agriculture, Office of Inspector General. 2015. FNS Quality Control Process for SNAP Error Rate. Audit Report No. 27601-0002-41. Washington, DC: USDA OIG, September 23, 2015.

Ward, Ronald. 2025. "Supplemental Nutrition Assistance Program Provisions of the One Big Beautiful Bill Act of 2025 — Information Memorandum." Memorandum to All SNAP State Agencies, All Regions. Alexandria, VA: Food and Nutrition Service, U.S. Department of Agriculture, September 4, 2025. https://www.fns.usda.gov/obbb/snap.

7 C.F.R. § 275.23(b) (2024).

10 Appendix A: Additional Figures

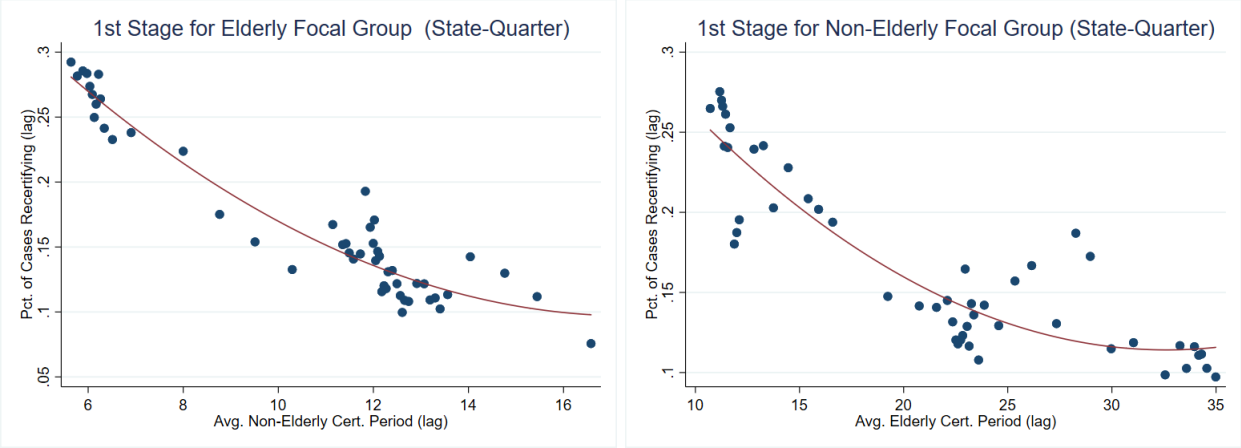


Figure 3: Unconditional Non-linearized 1st Stage Relationships: Binscatter of the 1st stage relationship between average certification period for the alternate group and the percent of all cases recertifying in a quarter.

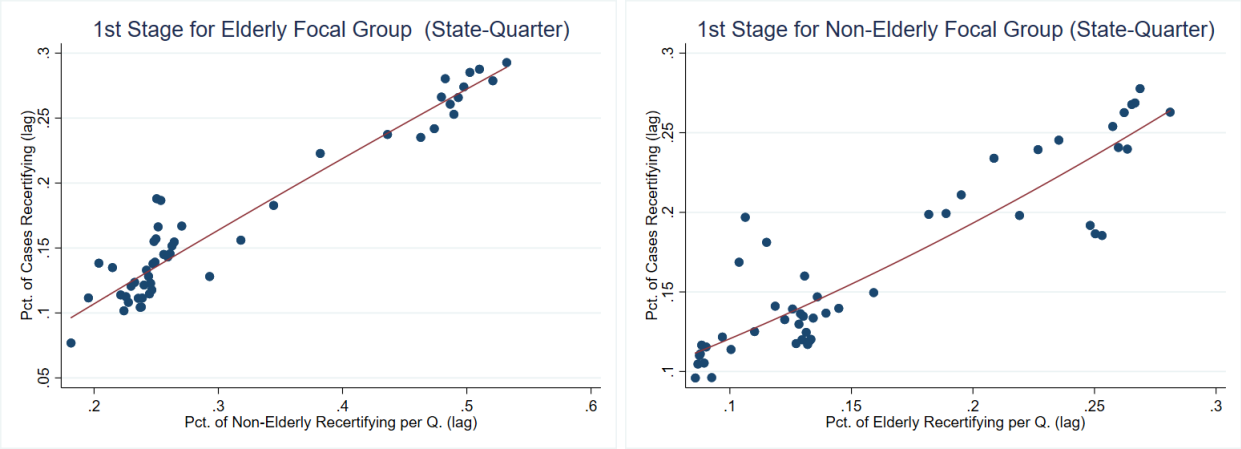


Figure 4: Unconditional Linearized 1st Stage Relationships: Binscatter of the 1st stage relationship between the expected percent of alternate group recertifying per quarter and the percent of all cases recertifying in a quarter.

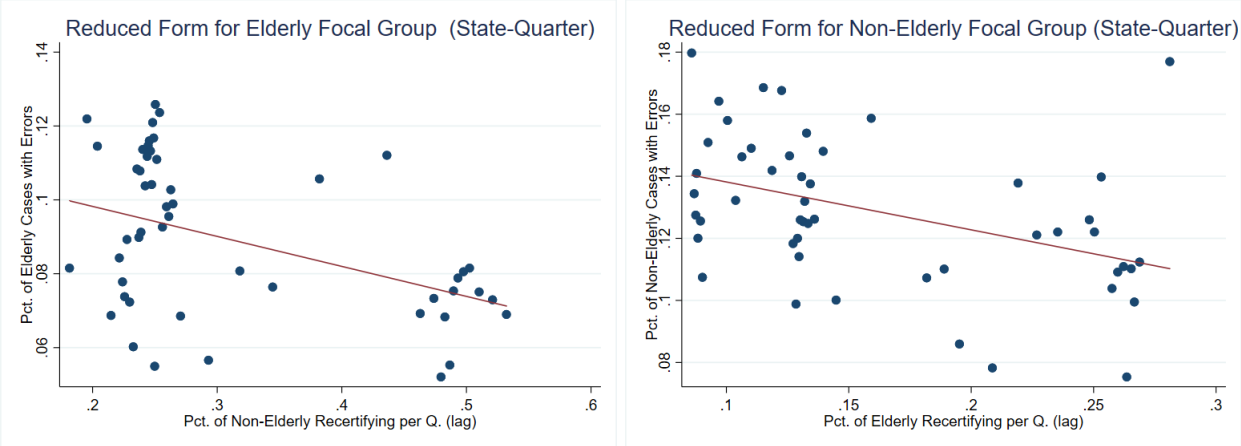


Figure 5: Unconditional Linearized Reduced Form Relationships: Binscatter of the reduced form relationship between the expected percent of alternate group recertifying per quarter and the Case Error Rate for the focal group.

11 Appendix B: Robustness Checks

Table 6: Alternative IV Estimates for the Case Error Rate by Focal Group (State-Quarter Level)

	Alt. Cert. Control		Not clustered		Participation Control		Not Lagged	
	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)	(5)	(6)	(7)	(8)
	Elderly	Non-elderly	Elderly	Non-elderly	Elderly	Non-elderly	Elderly	Non-elderly
Pct. of Cases Recertifying	0.0298	0.288*	0.0581	0.378	0.130	0.344	0.0714	0.437*
	(0.117)	(0.114)	(0.123)	(0.228)	(0.125)	(0.210)	(0.109)	(0.196)
Avg. Mo. Since Cert.	0.000354	0.00144						
	(0.000724)	(0.00153)						
Focal-Grp. Avg. Cert. Period			0.000716	0.00300	0.000763	0.00265	0.000834	0.00512
			(0.000907)	(0.00297)	(0.000823)	(0.00298)	(0.00122)	(0.00407)
Alt-Grp. Simplified Reporting Pct.	0.00278	0.00505	0.00299	0.00583	-0.00432	0.00489	-0.0116	0.00125
	(0.0165)	(0.00827)	(0.0164)	(0.0119)	(0.0147)	(0.00890)	(0.0153)	(0.00818)
Unemployment rate	-0.516	-0.695	-0.526	-0.728	-0.856	-1.130**	-0.296	-0.0724
	(0.495)	(0.396)	(0.456)	(0.532)	(0.467)	(0.367)	(0.353)	(0.470)
ESAP		0.0221**		0.0244*		0.0212*		0.0229**
		(0.00749)		(0.0119)		(0.00952)		(0.00799)
Participation Rate (lag)					0.101	0.0171		
					(0.0705)	(0.0615)		
Observations	601	601	601	601	589	589	601	601
KP rk Wald F-stat (excluded instrument)	225.4	55.00	378.0	46.93	230.3	23.28	53.40	13.32
Underidentification Test p-value	0.0299	0.107	0.000000458	0.0000521	0.0207	0.0599	0.00330	0.110
Anderson-Rubin Stat. (AR)	0.0611	4.840	0.228	3.610	1.001	2.528	0.403	4.094
AR p-value	0.806	0.0325	0.635	0.0632	0.322	0.118	0.528	0.0484

Standard errors in parentheses

Robust standard errors are reported in parentheses.

* $p < 0.05$, ** $p < 0.01$, *** $p < 0.001$

Table 7: IV Estimates for the Case Error Rate for Non-Elderly/Disabled Households (State-Quarter Level)

	Baseline	No ESAP	Linear ESAP
	(1)	(2)	(3)
Pct. of Cases Recertifying (lag)	0.378*	0.165	0.294
	(0.191)	(0.207)	(0.192)
Avg. Non-Elderly Cert. Period	0.00300	0.000983	0.00278
	(0.00281)	(0.00264)	(0.00280)
Elderly Simplified Reporting Pct. (lag)	0.00583	0.00589	0.0115
	(0.00895)	(0.00801)	(0.00915)
ESAP (lag)	0.0244**		
	(0.00876)		
Unemployment rate (lag)	-0.728	-0.671	-0.691
	(0.391)	(0.472)	(0.391)
ESAP Timetrend (lag)			0.00341**
			(0.00122)
Observations	601	601	601
KP rk Wald F-stat (excluded instrument)		54.95	59.30
Underidentification Test p-value		0.0174	0.0208
Anderson-Rubin Stat. (AR)	3.610	0.609	2.511
AR p-value	0.0632	0.439	0.119

Robust standard errors, clustered at the state level, are reported in parentheses.

* $p < 0.05$, ** $p < 0.01$, *** $p < 0.001$

12 Appendix C: ESAP Data Collection

I obtained the state implementation dates for the Elderly Simplified Application Project (ESAP) from a combination of news articles, legislative records, and other sources. I was only able to obtain an approximate ESAP implementation date for several states and territories, with the District of Columbia being the only one of these to implement ESAP during my period of study. I collected this data by having Claude search the internet and state records for information on state ESAP adoption. I then manually reviewed its sources and corrected its findings. Finally, I cross-checked the resulting list of implementation dates against the State Options Reports (Benvie et al. 2023, FNS 2018, McConnell et al. 2024, McConnell et al. 2025) and validated any inconsistencies.

Table 8: ESAP Effective Dates by State

State	Effective Quarter	Inexact Date
South Carolina	2004	Yes
Alabama	2008	Yes
Florida	2012Q3	Yes
Mississippi	2012Q3	Yes
Georgia	2012Q4	Yes
Washington	2013	Yes
Pennsylvania	2016Q2	
Maryland	2016Q4	
California	2017Q4	
Massachusetts	2018Q4	
Connecticut	2020Q3	
Vermont	2020Q4	
Arkansas	2021Q1	
New York	2021Q4	
Texas	2021Q4	
Virginia	2022Q1	
Arizona	2022Q3	
Ohio	2022Q3	
Illinois	2022Q4	
Rhode Island	2023Q1	
District of Columbia	2023Q2	Yes
Indiana	2023Q3	
Louisiana	2023Q3	
Kentucky	2023Q4	
New Mexico	2024Q4	

Notes: "Inexact Date" marks states for which the exact effective quarter could not be confirmed. Entries with a year only indicate that no quarter was identified.